

PELICAN BAY POLICE DEPARTMENT
HOMICIDE DIVISION — EIGHTH DISTRICT
715 South Broad Avenue, New Orleans, LA 70119
(504) 658-6080

WITNESS STATEMENT

Case No.: PBPB-2026-034532 | Document No.: 07

Witness Name: PHILLIP JOSEPH ARCENEUX

DOB / Age / Sex / Race: 02/09/1973 / 52 / Male / White

Address: 1812 St. Charles Ave., Apt. 11-C, New Orleans, LA 70130

Phone: 504-555-0379

Occupation: Owner/Manager, The Rusty Anchor (712 Bourbon Street); Managing Member, Olivier Hospitality, LLC

Date/Time of Statement: October 4, 2025 — 04:45 AM

Location of Interview: Office at 712 Bourbon Street (back office)

Interviewing Detective: Det. Yvette Landry, Badge #1887

Witnessing Officer: Officer Roland Martin, Badge #3318

Recording: Audio recorder PBPB-AR-1144 (file 10-04-002)

Witness Counsel Present: None (waived; written waiver on file)

Mr. Olivier responded to the scene voluntarily at 3:50 AM after being contacted by PBPB. He was advised of the homicide and that he was not a suspect at this time. Mr. Olivier waived the right to have counsel present for the initial interview but stated he might consult counsel before any follow-up.

Q: Mr. Olivier, you own The Rusty Anchor?

A: Yes, I'm the sole owner. Bought it in 2018. I'm here most nights, but I had stepped out by around midnight tonight. I was home when you called me.

Q: Who was running the bar tonight after you left?

A: Marisol. Marisol Acosta. She's my senior bartender, six years with me. There was also a barback, Miles Hebert, but he gets cut at 1 most nights.

Q: Did you see the victim, Damari Thornton, in the bar tonight?

A: I — I want to be careful here. I saw a Black guy come in around 11:30, maybe a quarter to 12. Sat at the corner of the bar nearest the back hall. Ordered an Abita. Stayed quiet. He wasn't bothering anybody. He didn't drink much — I saw him nursing the same beer for over an hour, I think. He had a notepad. I noticed because most folks have a phone, you know? Not a notepad.

Q: Did you speak with him?

A: I said hello when I walked past. He nodded. That's it. I didn't know his name.

Q: Are you aware now that he was a journalist?

A: (pause) Yes. You told me on the phone. That changes how I'm reading the whole night, to be honest.

Q: Why?

A: Because — look. We had an incident in August. A guy got jumped two doors down. The papers had a piece about it. There were rumors. I didn't want my place dragged into it. If he was looking into that, I might know why he was here.

Q: Tell me about the August incident.

A: August 17th, I think. A tourist from Wisconsin got beat up pretty bad behind Marie's, which is the bar next door south of me. He'd been in my place earlier in the night. Cops talked to me then too. I didn't have anything for them. I still don't. But there's been talk — a couple of regulars who are real, you know, real present in the bar. People who hold court. And if someone's poking around about them, things get tense.

Q: Who are the regulars you're referring to?

A: I'm — Detective, I'd like to choose my words careful here. There's a group of three or four guys who come in most weekends. I know names because I run their tabs. Trent Cormier is the main one. He owns a bar supply business — he actually delivers to me. Marco Pellegrino comes in with him a lot. There's a Kyle, I don't know his last name. And sometimes another guy, an older one. I'm not saying any of them did anything. I'm saying when you ask who's around, it's them.

Q: Were any of them in the bar tonight?

A: Trent and Marco, yes. I saw them at the back high-top when I left. Kyle I'm not sure about, I think yes. They were drinking but not falling-down. Trent was being loud — that's not unusual for him.

Q: Did you see any interaction between any of them and Mr. Thornton?

A: I didn't, not while I was there. But I left around 11:50. Marisol might have seen more.

Q: Is there a back door to your establishment that lets out into the alley?

A: Yes. Staff door. Customers don't usually go that way but it's not locked from the inside during operating hours — fire code. People do use it to smoke. The alley camera you saw — that's mine. I put it up two years ago because of some break-ins.

Q: Will you consent to the seizure and forensic copying of the camera's recording?

A: Yes. I told the officer earlier — I'll sign whatever you need. The system is a DVR back here in this office. The model is a Hikvision. The footage retains thirty days. It's all there.

Q: Mr. Olivier, did any of these regulars contact you tonight, after the bar closed?

A: (pause) Trent called me at — I have to check — around 3:30. I didn't pick up. He left a voicemail. He said something like 'hey, call me when you can, it's important.' I didn't call back yet. I figured I'd ask y'all what I should do.

Q: We'll handle that. Please don't return that call without speaking to us first.

A: Understood.

Q: Is there anything else you think we should know?

A: (long pause) I'll just say this: if Trent was involved in what happened tonight, I'm not surprised. I'm not happy about it, but I'm not surprised. I've been thinking for a while that there's something not right with that crew. If they did this, you have my full cooperation. I'll close my doors for a week if I have to.

END OF STATEMENT — 05:32 AM

Witness consented to immediate copying of DVR footage. Officer Martin remained on premises with Mr. Olivier pending Digital Forensics arrival. Search warrant for camera contents was applied for as a procedural safeguard and signed at 9:02 AM by Magistrate Guidry.

Witness Signature: _____ Gerard Olivier

Interviewing Detective: _____ Det. R. Landry #1887

Witness to Statement: _____ Officer J. Martin #3318